



SEA URCHINS

The main enemies of giant kelp are sea urchins, especially a species known as the purple sea urchin. These spiny relatives of starfish have tough teeth on their undersides that they use to nibble away at the kelp fronds and devour them. They often attack the kelp in swarms, and if they get the chance, a big swarm of sea urchins can destroy large areas of kelp forest.

◀ PRICKLY PROBLEM

This gang of hungry sea urchins will soon chew through the tough kelp stalks.

URCHIN HUNTERS

Luckily for the kelp forest, sea urchins are the favorite prey of the sea otters that hunt in these waters. The otters dive to the seabed to find the urchins, and bring them back up to the surface.

They use stones to smash open the urchins so they can feast on the soft flesh inside, avoiding the sharp spines.



GIANT OCTOPUS

One of the biggest animals that lives among the kelp is the Pacific giant octopus, which has arms that can span up to 14 ft (4.3 m). It preys on fish and shellfish such as crabs, lobsters, and clams. Like all octopuses, it is very intelligent, with a good memory and sharp senses.

▼ SHARK SNACK

A dead shark on the seabed makes an easy meal for this giant octopus. Like many hunters, the octopus is a scavenger too.

